

PASSPORT
TO MARKED CARDS
Written by Phillip Smith

CONTENTS

Introduction	3
On the Optical Marking System	5
Lightning	8
O.P.	11
The Archive	15
Skeleton Key	19
Swapola	22
Evil Twin	24
Obvious Date	26
Dodo	28
Savant	30
Additional Resources	32

Copyright © 2018 by Phillip Smith

All rights reserved. This book or any portion thereof may not be reproduced or used in any manner whatsoever without the express written permission of the publisher except for the use of brief quotations in a book review.

Printed in the UK

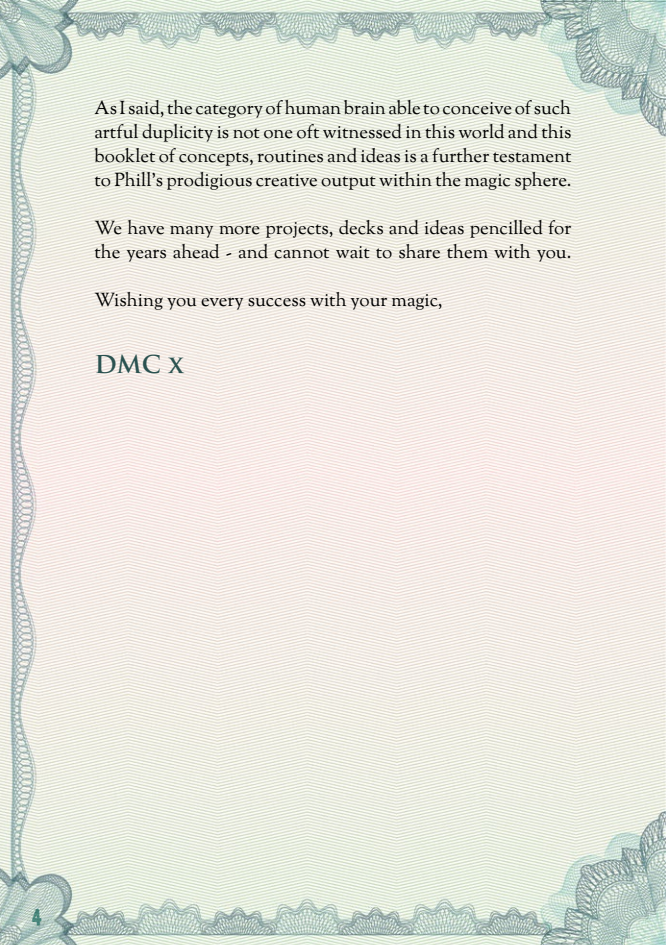
INTRODUCTION

BY DRUMMOND MONEY-COUTTS

By any yardstick - Phill Smith is not an ordinary creature. First glimpsing his ingenious 'Optical Marking System' on my computer screen in 2013 ranks as one of my most exciting moments in card magic - the seemingly inscrutable randomness of the back design instantly morphing into crystalline clarity.

Since that first Eureka moment all elements of the marking system, box design, card stock and finish have been finessed to bring you today what is perhaps the greatest marked deck for magicians ever made. What began life already as a twelve-gauge shotgun now boasts flamethrower attachments and hand grenade capabilities - this new version of ELITES offering four-corner, two-directional read capabilities for the very first time. This quantum upgrade, coupled with our studied analysis of the orientation of each single pip around the markings, today allows you an unprecedented freedom of 'read' from almost any angle - and from up to 8-10 feet away.

Regarding the card stock itself, through the years we have experimented with many of the world's most prominent card manufacturers and have endured all manner of delays, misprints, smudged inks, hidden costs and other such muppetry. And so, listening to the requests from the many thousands of you around the world - for the very first time we now bring you the ELITES on the finest card stock available from the world's favourite card manufacturer, the United States Playing Card Company.



As I said, the category of human brain able to conceive of such artful duplicity is not one oft witnessed in this world and this booklet of concepts, routines and ideas is a further testament to Phill's prodigious creative output within the magic sphere.

We have many more projects, decks and ideas pencilled for the years ahead - and cannot wait to share them with you.

Wishing you every success with your magic,

DMC x

ON THE OPTICAL MARKING SYSTEM

The marking system of the DMC ELITES is a system we refer to as the Optical Marking System and it is unique to our products.

There are two kinds of marking systems commonly used in playing cards - coded systems and reader systems:

Coded marking systems are marked in such a way that some detail of the back design differs on each card, and there is a system that allows this information to be decoded and converted into the value of the card (for example, a circular detail may be marked in a clock-like fashion, whereby the 'hour' indicated corresponds to the appropriate value of the card).

Coded systems are commonly applied to existing cards, either with a pen or by scratching the back, and they have the benefit of being generally difficult to discover, but the correlating drawback is that they can be hard to actually sight in use. They can be fantastic for use in gaming, where cards are often in clear view for an extended period of time and you have plenty of time to get your peek.

Reader cards are by contrast far easier to read since they literally say what the value and suit are. Typically this is done in the actual printing of the deck as in the GT Speedreader deck or the Phoenix marked deck, but there have been methods to do this to your existing decks, simply using a white pen to write the value on the back. Reader cards

are generally very quick to read, but can also be a little transparent to curious spectators - if an audience member asks if your cards are marked, it can be a little nervy to hand out a very clearly marked card for examination.

The Optical Marking System is technically a reader deck, but it differs in that there is nothing added to the back design. The mark is made by the orientation of the lozenges that make up the regular back pattern, and although it is very easy to read at a range, even in dark rooms, once you know the system, it is nigh on impenetrable for the curious audience member.

So how does the system work? The normal back is made up of 2328 diamond shaped lozenges, each of which is oriented at an angle that is randomised by software. The markings are made by manually adjusting the angle of the lozenges to create channels that correspond to the value and suit of the card. Because there is no change to the density of the pattern and no deviation from the positioning or size of the lozenges, and no addition or removal, without being primed to see the marks it is very difficult to find them. This is the unique benefit of the Optical Marking System.

People familiar with marked cards will also know of a common technique to spot the marks on a deck - riffling the ends like a flickbook has the effect of making any marks on the back of the cards 'dance' around, in contrast to the static back design. Realising our system was vulnerable to this attack, we reinforced it by ensuring that the lozenges that don't make up the marks are all randomised, not just relative to each other but throughout the deck, across every card. This means that when you riffle the ends, the flickbook effect

means that the entire back shifts slightly, making it much harder to spot the marks this way. It has always given me great pleasure to see someone, frustrated by their inability to spot the marks, flick through the end only to end up even more flummoxed.

The 2018 Green edition of the DMC ELITES playing cards is the 4th version of the ELITES, and the 5th iteration of the Optical Marking System since it was originally introduced on the Great Whites deck. Each successive version of the system has been redesigned and adjusted based on our experiences and those of users to ensure that the system is as useful as we can make it. Each edition has had minuscule changes to the marks themselves to ensure the best positioning between legibility and obscurity, and we have added suit repeaters beneath the main marks, marked all four corners, shifted the o of the 10 to an X to differentiate between 10 and the Queen, strengthened the one way marking and even revised and standardised the faces.

The marks are very simple, very useable, and thanks to the input and feedback of our users, as good as we can possibly make them. However, having a great deck of marked cards does not automatically convey upon the owner the immediate power to do miracles. You have to learn how to use them to their best effect. To that end, there follows a selection of powerful pieces of magic that put the ELITES to work in a range of devious ways...



LIGHTNING



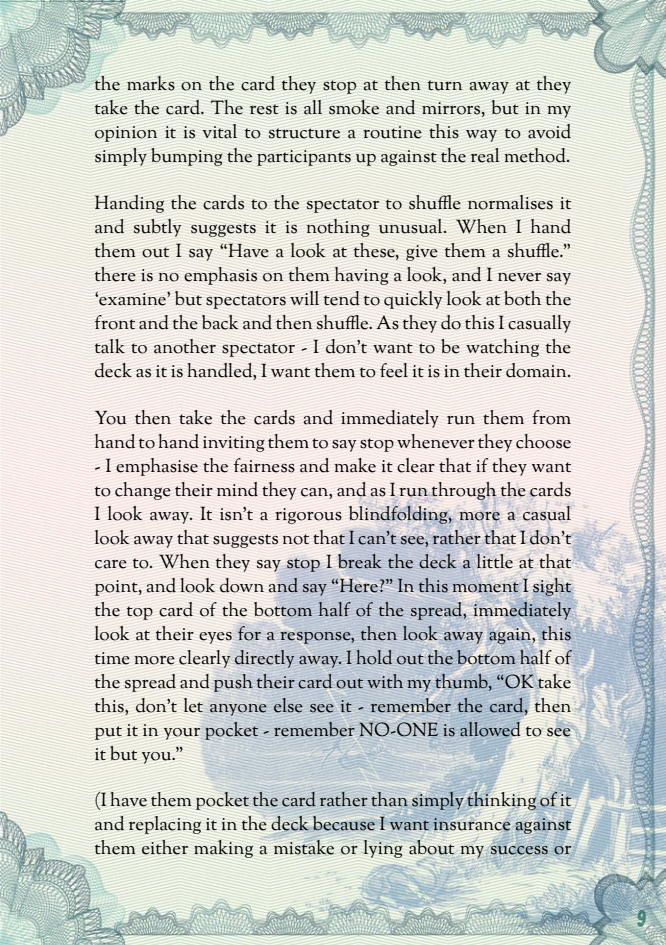
EFFECT

Your spectators shuffle a deck and hand it to you, and you then run the cards between your hands inviting them to say stop whenever they like. They do, and you very fairly hand them the card they stopped at whilst looking away. You tell them to look at and remember the card, making sure no-one else sees, and then put it into their pocket.

"If I were so inclined, I could now go through the rest of the deck and see which card is missing, and know which card you had removed that way. Very simple, but terrible magic. Instead, I've learnt another way - hold your finger out like this:" You point your index finger out in front of you, and have them do the same. "Imagine the information about the card being conducted down like a lightning bolt, down from your brain, right down your arm, down into the very tip of your finger..." You reach up with your own finger and very slowly bring it towards their fingertip. "...and when I close the circuit that lightning will spark across to my finger, up my arm, into my brain and in a flash..." you touch the very tip of your finger to theirs... "The Jack of Diamonds." They take the card from their pocket and show it: the lightning struck true - it is the Jack of Diamonds. Shocking.

METHOD

The method is simplicity itself of course, but the presentation is sufficiently layered that it barely matters. All you do is sight



the marks on the card they stop at then turn away at they take the card. The rest is all smoke and mirrors, but in my opinion it is vital to structure a routine this way to avoid simply bumping the participants up against the real method.

Handing the cards to the spectator to shuffle normalises it and subtly suggests it is nothing unusual. When I hand them out I say "Have a look at these, give them a shuffle." there is no emphasis on them having a look, and I never say 'examine' but spectators will tend to quickly look at both the front and the back and then shuffle. As they do this I casually talk to another spectator - I don't want to be watching the deck as it is handled, I want them to feel it is in their domain.

You then take the cards and immediately run them from hand to hand inviting them to say stop whenever they choose - I emphasise the fairness and make it clear that if they want to change their mind they can, and as I run through the cards I look away. It isn't a rigorous blindfolding, more a casual look away that suggests not that I can't see, rather that I don't care to. When they say stop I break the deck a little at that point, and look down and say "Here?" In this moment I sight the top card of the bottom half of the spread, immediately look at their eyes for a response, then look away again, this time more clearly directly away. I hold out the bottom half of the spread and push their card out with my thumb, "OK take this, don't let anyone else see it - remember the card, then put it in your pocket - remember NO-ONE is allowed to see it but you."

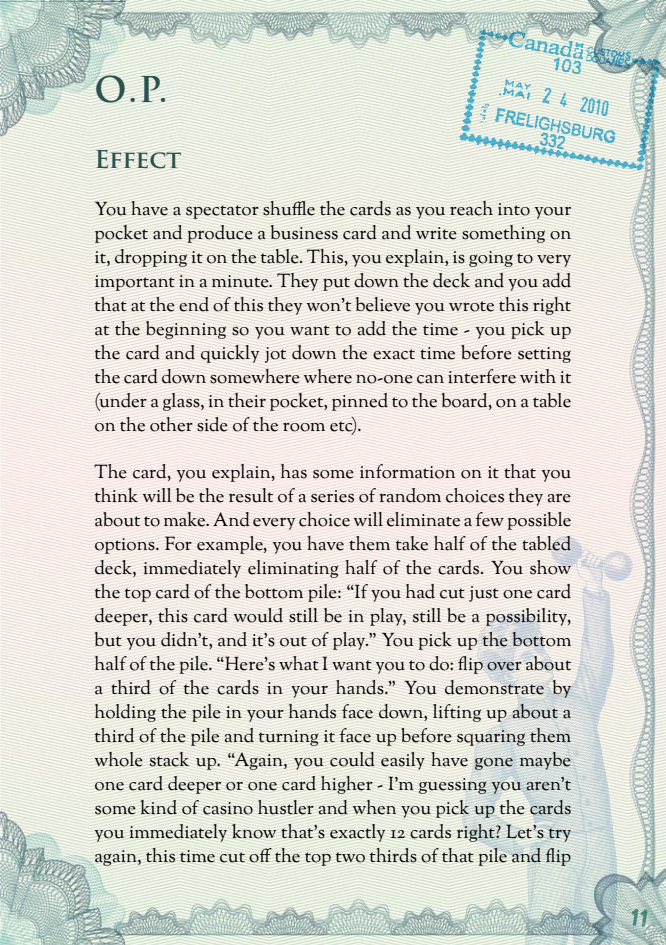
(I have them pocket the card rather than simply thinking of it and replacing it in the deck because I want insurance against them either making a mistake or lying about my success or

otherwise in the trick - this is a hard learned lesson!)

They do this, you immediately square up the deck and pocket it or put it on the table, whilst still looking away, using this broad motion to more completely turn your body away. I want them to remember that there was no way I could have seen their card at the moment when THEY saw it. Don't mention that you aren't looking, just don't look! "Done?" I then turn back. At this point I ideally want there to be no cards in play because I want them to focus on the ideas and conversation rather than the physical cards. I of course now know what their card is from sighting the marks, and I can drop into the lightning bolt presentation.

The presentation is all about sharpening the moment and putting maximum focus on that exact moment when you touch your finger to theirs, a moment when... nothing happens! By building this moment you ensure that when they think of this routine, that moment is what they think of, not any of the structure or process by which they arrived at the card.

The OMS is very flexible and very powerful and sometimes it is tempting to use the deck in quite a blunt way, because you know that they won't see the marks, for example. You could have them pick a card and simply tell them what it is. My recommendation however is to always create a layer of presentational insulation that they can focus on. It creates greater misdirection, stronger magic, and more impactful and engaging theatre. The lightning presentation is about replacing the focus on the cards, getting rid of them entirely from view, and concentrating on the idea of the card, and the physicality of the conducting process.



O.P.

EFFECT

You have a spectator shuffle the cards as you reach into your pocket and produce a business card and write something on it, dropping it on the table. This, you explain, is going to be very important in a minute. They put down the deck and you add that at the end of this they won't believe you wrote this right at the beginning so you want to add the time - you pick up the card and quickly jot down the exact time before setting the card down somewhere where no-one can interfere with it (under a glass, in their pocket, pinned to the board, on a table on the other side of the room etc).

The card, you explain, has some information on it that you think will be the result of a series of random choices they are about to make. And every choice will eliminate a few possible options. For example, you have them take half of the tabled deck, immediately eliminating half of the cards. You show the top card of the bottom pile: "If you had cut just one card deeper, this card would still be in play, still be a possibility, but you didn't, and it's out of play." You pick up the bottom half of the pile. "Here's what I want you to do: flip over about a third of the cards in your hands." You demonstrate by holding the pile in your hands face down, lifting up about a third of the pile and turning it face up before squaring them whole stack up. "Again, you could easily have gone maybe one card deeper or one card higher - I'm guessing you aren't some kind of casino hustler and when you pick up the cards you immediately know that's exactly 12 cards right? Let's try again, this time cut off the top two thirds of that pile and flip

them over.”

You demonstrate again, cutting two thirds of the cards in your hand and turning them over on top of the rest of the pile.

“Random choices right? Let’s see where they have left us - turn over the whole pile and go through until you find the last face up card. That’s your card.” You show them what to do, turning the whole pile over in your hand. “Look - that would be my card, the 5H, and just one cut one time one card different and it would have been this card, or this one, or this one. Right? But it wasn’t any of these, because this is about YOUR random choices, not mine. What was your card?”

The mirror your actions and show the last face up card. It is the 7C.

“You shuffled, you cut, you cut and you cut again, and each time you were eliminating possibilities down to just one - this card, the 7C.” You have them retrieve your prediction and read it aloud. It bears the time, five minutes ago, and the card they chose: the 7 of Clubs.

METHOD

OP stands for Open Prediction, as well as Over Powered, a term to describe a videogame character who is more powerful than they should be. That’s this effect - it shouldn’t be as strong as it is, relying as it does on a very old overlooked force, but it’s a beast.

The method starts with a very subtle miscall that adds to

the misdirection. The first thing you write AS they are shuffling is the time. You table the prediction, then when they finish shuffling and put the deck down, you sight the top card. This is your force card, and you decide to write the time down, but of course you actually write down this card on your prediction. This isn't a strong deception but it is a solid convincer. Attentive audiences will remember you wrote down the card before they had even finished shuffling. (If you don't feel like working this subtlety into the routine, simply skip it and make your prediction once they have finished shuffling)

You are now going to force this top card using the vintage Balducci Cut Deeper force (first published in Ed Balducci's effect "The All-fair Coincidence" in Hugard's Magic Monthly, Vol. 14 No. 6, Nov. 1956). Although it is processy the Cut Deeper force happens entirely in the spectator's hands and as a result it can be very deceptive.

Have them pick up the top half of the deck and highlight that if they had cut one card deeper they would have picked a different card. Crucially, when you show the top card of the bottom pile, make sure to lose it in the centre because otherwise it will reappear when you demo the mechanics of the cut deeper process.

They now cut the top third of their pile and flip it over, then the top two thirds and flip that over, then turn the whole pile over and go through the cards to find the last face up card. This is a variation of the Cut Deeper force that emphasises the fairness. Everything happens in the open, and they can plainly see all the other cards they could have chosen. The card they reach should, provided they have followed your

instructions correctly, be the top card you sighted right at the beginning.

The Cut Deeper force is a very old method and because a lot of magicians learn it early in their development it's often considered a weak method. In this context however, combined with the ELITES marked deck, it is really quite powerful and very hard to backtrack since you don't even touch the deck between them shuffling it and making this selection. If you don't like the Cut Deeper force and want to bypass it entirely then you can simply have them look at the top card of the shuffled deck. This will still yield a strong effect, but the process and time misdirection supplied by the Cut Deeper force adds a great deal to the effect.

All that remains is to unpack the prediction with as much drama as possible. I like to recap what happened and highlight all the different points where the final result could have been changed. This final revelation can be extremely strong.



THE ARCHIVE



EFFECT

The deck is given a thorough shuffle before being handed to you. You very purposefully look away, explaining that you don't want to see the cards, front or backs as they choose. You spread the cards from hand to hand and invite the spectator to say stop at any moment they choose. They do this, and you display the card they stopped at for them to remember, still looking away, before replacing it in the deck and squaring the deck up. IMMEDIATELY, still looking away, you hand the deck to the spectator to shuffle. You look back as they shuffle the cards. You take them back and spread the cards face down, explaining that their card is now totally lost.

"If I were to go through this deck, face up, and find your card in the deck, that would be pretty good right? After all, you shuffled to begin with, chose a card, then shuffled again, all whilst my eyes were pointed over here... most people would say it's lost forever?"

They agree - that would be pretty good.

"I can't do that." You confess. "I don't need to - your card was the 8S." You are dead right. As a ridiculous, superfluous flourish, without breaking eye contact, you slowly turn over the top card - it is their card.



METHOD

In the Archive uses a feature of the deck that has been strongly enhanced with this edition of the deck - the one-way marking. Put simply, this means that the back of the cards are not symmetrical, and there is a top and a bottom to each card. To begin with, before performing In the Archive, you need to prepare the deck to make sure that all of the cards are oriented the same way. An easy way to do this is to deal the cards into two piles from the randomised deck, right way up cards in one pile, upsidedown cards in the other. This will seem a random deal as you will deal a bunch to one, then a bunch to the other, then one to this pile, two to that etc. Then you rotate one pile round and riffle shuffle or just jam the two piles into one. This will make sure they are all the same way round.

Now, the spectators should be able to give the deck a normal overhand shuffle without disrupting this one way arrangement.

The idea of the one way marking is that if one card in the deck is reversed, it is easy to spot it amongst the others. The method for their selection accomplishes that in this routine, and 'flags' that card as their chosen card, although of course you don't make the read until later.

The way I do this is quite simple and nicely deceptive - the card is rotated 180° as you display it. You break the spread so their card is the top of the left half of the spread and your right hand comes across the top of the card and takes it onto the front of the right half of the spread, holding it up to display - it is then put back in place and the deck squared up,

their card having been turned around 180°.

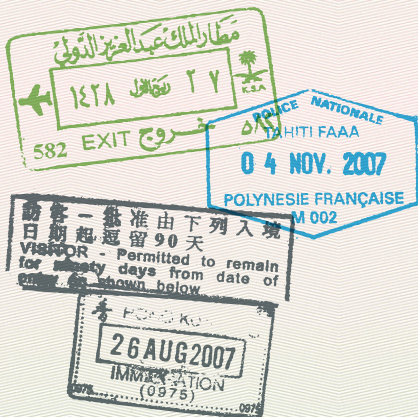
You must of course learn to do this whilst looking pointedly away. They remember their card, ideally a friend also will see it so they aren't free to get it wrong, and you immediately hand them the deck to shuffle. This is a powerful moment because they will be on the lookout for funny business - there is none to see. They give the cards a genuine free shuffle, and as I hand them the cards I subtly show my hands are empty.

Don't let them shuffle for too long, but don't panic either. Look back and take the cards back casually and begin to spread them between your hands as you explain that their card is lost. As you go through the cards you are looking for the reversed card - it should be easy to spot. Once you see it, place your forefinger on the face of the card and carry on spreading whilst keeping this finger in place. Look up at the spectator, split the deck at that place, gesture subtly with the cards and when you square the cards up make sure that this reversed card goes on top of the deck. Now you can sight it.

You can now build the revelation as much as you want. Everything is already done even though it seems quite impossible. The verbal revelation of the card is extremely strong, and I like to let that moment play for a bit before dropping the final bomb of flipping the top card over.

This effect uses a delayed read - you tag their card by rotating it, putting it in the archive for later reference, and read it at your leisure. This is a great way to handle things because the two methods cancel each other out even if spectators suspect one or the other - knowing the deck is one-way they may understand how you can locate their card, but not how

you know its value. Similarly, knowing the deck is marked doesn't explain how you know which card is theirs since you are able to look away the whole time it is visibly in play. Only the very specific combination of the two methods can explain how you create the final effect.



SKELETON KEY

EFFECT

The spectator shuffles the deck and cuts it to the table. You have them take a bunch of cards out from the deck however they like - they can cut a bunch off the top, take a load out from the middle, cut some from the bottom, deal them into piles - however they choose, you make it clear that their decision is totally free. They do this, and you tell them that there was a chance they could have seen some of those cards as they did so, so you instruct them to shuffle the cards they have taken, ideally under the table, or wherever.

Again, you explain that maybe they think you have seen some of the cards in their hands, so you turn your back. You tell them to shuffle the cards in their hands one last time, square them up, then look at and remember the face card of that pile. They do this, and before you turn back you have them drop this pile on top of the tabled cards and then to cut the whole deck so it is hopelessly lost in the pack. You turn back and take the deck off the table.

"I wanted you to feel like everything so far has been fair because at the end of this I don't want you to feel like I made you pick a particular card or whatever - this isn't really a trick like that, this is something real I've learned to do, and to be honest I still don't really understand how it works." You turn the deck face up spread the cards in a messy pile all over the table, then take your phone out and snap a photo of the whole mess. You show the photo to one of the spectators and zoom in on a single card until the index fills the screen. "I

don't know why, but I think... this one." you say, motioning for them to say nothing. You then tell the participant to reach out and touch the card they had chosen. You turn the phone around and show that you had correctly identified their exact card.

METHOD

The revelation in this piece is weird and kind of specific, but in practice it feels very organic and spontaneous. You could of course unpack it any one of a million ways, but this presentation is memorable and intriguing.

The method is another delayed read, similar to the effect In the Archive, except in this routine you tag their chosen card not with its orientation but with its proximity to an impromptu key card. The extremely free handling of them taking a bunch of cards from the deck is smoke to draw their attention away from the moment when they are holding a load of cards and the rest of the deck is on the table. The free choices they are making, the shuffles and the cuts before they look at their card are all happening to the cards in their hands, whereas the tabled cards are in fact where the action happens that will allow the method for the effect. As soon as the tabled half of the deck is static, once all the initial shuffling and cutting etc is done, you note the top card. This is your key card.

You go through the presentation as described above, and when they put the packet of cards down on top of this tabled pile, their chosen card will be on top of your key card. They can now cut the deck to their heart's content without

disrupting this pair. Shuffling the cards does risk disturbing the pair so make sure they just cut the cards unless you feel like rolling the dice.

When you spread the cards face up at the end, you are looking for the key you memorised - the card physically beneath that card in the face up spread is the spectator's chosen card. The phone revelation is intended to justify the face up spread, and you need to make sure that one of the spectators sees what you do so they don't think it is some kind of clever app or phone trick or whatever. I specifically don't have them say the name of their card because I don't want anyone to think that this is some kind of voice recognition thing.

If you are performing for just one person it can be interesting to let them see the process and gradually zoom bit by bit seemingly random bit into the image until their chosen card fills the screen. It creates a sense of intrigue as they will look intently for what it could possibly be that you are doing to figure out their card, and of course there is nothing to find.

It is of course also possible to do this revelation at the end with the deck face down, simply remember that their card will now be the one above the key card not below it. When I do this I have them reach out with their finger, which I then hold and move back and forth across the mess of cards, apparently narrowing down to their card in a muscle-reading kind of way. I drop their finger down onto their card, then look them in the eye and say "If that card is the 8H are you going to go nuts?" This off hand revelation of the card is a gut punch since there is no way you could know this. When the excitement has died down you let go of their hand and leave them to turn over the card for a second powerful hit.

SWAPOLA

EFFECT

The audience member shuffles the cards and deals three cards at random into a face-down row on the table, boxing the rest of the deck. You turn your back, and explain that they are to peek the face of one of the cards, then, in case they perhaps thought that they had maybe minutely moved the peeked card in a way that can be discerned, actually swap the positions of the other two cards.

With your back still turned you raise your hand up like you are swearing in / about to give a high five, then you turn back round, glance down at the cards then slam your hand down on one of them. Your hand completely covers the card. "You picked this card right?" as soon as they agree you put your finger to your lips and shush them. You slowly close your eyes before blurting out "The 5 of Hearts." This is, of course, correct.

METHOD

Swapola works using a very old logical principle from Bob Hummer's Mental Monte: it's very easy to perform and yet has the power to hit very hard. When the three cards are initially dealt down you note the value and suit of one of the cards as well as its position. You now turn away, and give clear verbal instructions to the audience member as outlined above. When you turn back, you will immediately be able to tell which card was peeked:

If the card you spotted earlier is in the same position as it was when you noted it, then this is the card that they peeked - the other two indifferent cards have been swapped, and the only card to remain in position is the peeked card.

If the card has swapped, then neither it, nor the indifferent card that is now in the space it previously occupied were the peeked cards. The card in the other space is the one that was peeked. You need only now read the back of this card to determine what card the punter is thinking of.

The logic behind this is quite simple but I recommend practicing a few times to get the hang of exactly how it works and why - once you have a full grasp of it the routine is very simple, but if you don't spend a while with the idea and try and busk it, you will make mistakes.

I like to make the revelation in the manner presented above - raising your hand with your back turned kind of extends that moment back before there is any way you could know - you visually begin the process that ends with you finding their card before you have even turned back. I turn back, very quickly sight the card I started with, note its position and therefore the position of the card they chose and then sight the value and suit of that card. This happens very quickly but needs practice to get fast. When I bring my hand down I slam it down loud enough to make them jump - this is an obnoxious thing to do but it focuses everything on that exact moment. From that point, with your hand covering that card, you don't take your hand away from the card - it feels quite dramatic and is a memorable image for the audience.

EVIL TWIN

EFFECT

You have the spectator shuffle the deck, and hand it to you. You dribble the cards from hand to hand instructing them to say “stop” whenever they care to and you hand them the dribbled block of cards. You turn your back to ensure you cannot cheat.

They deal down cards until they want to stop and then hand you the undealt cards. The remaining cards they deal into two piles. They pick one of these piles, shuffle it and hand it to you, you of course still have your back turned. The other pile they take, peek the top card then shuffle it.

As they are shuffling it you ask “If I now turned to face you, and you handed me that pile, and I looked through it and could pick out the card you thought of, would you be impressed?”

Of course, it’s a cool trick. You don’t turn back though, and they never hand you the cards. You simply tell them their card before they’ve even stopped shuffling the packet.

METHOD

The method is a classic inference read. You essentially force one of two cards using the double deal force and by sighting one of these two cards in the portion they hand to you you know which card they look at, without seeing it.

Here's the meat: they shuffle the cards and you take them back, and in dribbling down the cards, when they say stop, you thumb spread the top two cards of the bottom pile, just enough to read the marks, and memorise those two cards. These are the cards your procedure will force (although you will each only see one).

They take this bottom pile and deal through until they want to stop, handing you the undealt cards. The two force cards are now the bottom two cards of the tabled pile. So when they deal this pile into two piles, each pile will have one of the force cards on top. They pick up a pile of their choice and shuffle it before handing it to you.

You now quickly go through this pile, scanning for one of the two force cards using either the marked backs (if there are additional spectators) or simply by running through the faces (if there aren't, or you don't care). Whichever of the force cards you spot here, they of course will have peeked the other and you can structure and make your revelation as you see fit.



OBVIOUS DATE

EFFECT

You hand the cards to a spectator and look away, explaining that you want them to go through the cards and take out a number of cards that adds up to their birthdate. "Mine is the 21st, so I could take out a five, a six, a three and a seven, that adds up to twenty one, you see? Or a two, a four, a ten and a five. Also adds up to twenty one. So think of your birthdate, don't tell me what it is of course, and take out cards that add up to that number - just put them in a pile on the table please, face down." Once they have done this you tell them to add one card that has a value that matches the month of their birth. "So, I was born in August so I would put an 8 down on top. Think of the month you were born in, and add a card with that value on top of the face down pile. Jack is November, Queen is December by the way." When they have done this you briefly turn back and point to the face down pile "OK shuffle that now please, then hand it to me when you are happy it's all mixed."

You take the mixed pile and look through it. "There are so many different combinations here, in isolation it's impossible to work out, but of course you are such an OBVIOUS Autumn baby that your birthday has to be the 12th of October." It, of course, is just so.

METHOD

The method is simplicity itself: when they have built the

pile of cards and added the month card on top you simply turn back in talking to them and peek the value of the top card - you don't even need the suit, it is irrelevant. When you take the cards back you simply separate that card from the rest, work out the month, then add up the rest of the cards to learn the date.

This is a great example of a 'cards plus' effect, where you use the logic of the OMS to access a piece of personal information from the spectators.



DODO

EFFECT

As the deck is being shuffled by an audience member you produce a business card from your pocket and write a prediction on it, tabling it to the side. You then spread the deck and explain that you are thinking of a single playing card, and you are going to see if any of the group can read your mind and find it. Each person can reach forward and slide a card of their own choice out, without looking.

You scoop up the deck and look through it. "Let's see if my card is still in here..." you stop and take a card out. "Ah, sorry guys looks like no-one took it out, I'm afraid no-one wins the Ferrari tonight." You turn the card over and show it's the 7 of Hearts. "OK, turn your cards over and we'll see if anyone was even close." The punters have a range of different cards, one of them, Mike, has the 8 of Hearts. "Mike, OMG you were so close to winning the Ferrari. Sorry. Anyway, you suck, but let's see if my prediction was any better..." You turn over your prediction which reads "Mike will get the suit dead on, but get the value wrong by JUST ONE!"

"Never mind Mike, maybe next time."

METHOD

The method to this piece is a super simple, very sneaky bit of cheek. You begin by deciding which audience member you want to be the closest, and write the prediction, as above,

with their name.

You then proceed as described in the effect, having the various participants slide out their cards from the spread deck - you have simply to note the card that your chosen punter slides out. When you spread through the deck to find your supposed thought-of card, you simply find the card that is immediately next to it, to fulfill your prediction. The rest of the piece will simply play itself out.



SAVANT

EFFECT

Ask the spectators to shuffle and mix the deck because you want to stop doing card tricks and show them a genuine weird skill you have. They are to take the deck under the table, and without looking at it, and without you being able to see it, to take a single card from somewhere in the middle of the deck, and to reverse it, so it is face up in the face down deck.

They then bring the deck into view on the table. You take the deck and explain that if you were to go through the face up deck you would be able to work out what card was face down, by spotting all the Aces, and if there is only three, you know it is an Ace that's turned over, and you can check the suits and know which it is.

And if there are four Aces, check for Twos, and if there is one missing then you know it's a Two, etc. For most people this process takes about four minutes. You say you can do it a bit faster.

You have one of the punters get the stopwatch on their phone ready, and you say 'GO' then spread the deck face up and sweep your eyes across it - one card clearly face down in the middle. You sweep your eyes back again then square up the deck and turn it face down.

"STOP!" you say. "How long did I take?"

"Seven seconds." says the spectator.

"Wow, that's not a bad time. Now the tricky bit:" you step back from the table and look up as if visualising the spread deck, your eyes darting back and forth as you mentally walk through the process of finding the various cards in the deck. Eventually you stop and smile. "Right. If that one card is the Six of... Clubs, that's a new record for me. Six of clubs."

You spread the deck again, sliding out the single face down card before dramatically turning it over. It is the Six of Clubs.

METHOD

The method is clearly spectacularly simple, you simply sight the face down card and determine its value from the back. This effect is all presentation - your aim is to create the sense that you are really doing what you say you are doing.

I make a conscious decision to think about this piece differently to a card trick - it's not a card trick, it's a party piece I sometimes do that uses a real skill that I have developed. This mindset is important and can give your performance a shift in pacing that creates a real feeling of excitement amongst your audiences. You handle everything exactly as though it were real, down to genuinely visualising the deck in the air when you are apparently trying to work out what their card is. This approach is very strong.



ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

HIDDEN IN PLAIN SIGHT

Kirk Charles & Boris Wild

This book is a great next step in using a marked deck, containing information specific to the Boris Wild marked deck, a well known reader deck.

THE MARK OF THE DEVIL

Paul Voodini

6 effects from the mind of UK mentalist Paul Voodini, all using a marked deck.

ULTIMATE MARKED DECK COMPANION

Ivan Laplaud

Written to explain the ironically named Ultimate Marked Deck, this book contains 36 routines that are also compatible with the ELITES deck.

TED LESLEY'S WORKING PERFORMER'S MARKED DECK MANUAL

by Ted Lesley & Eric Mason & David Britland

The late Ted Lesley ushered in the era of practical reader decks and this book contains a boatload of material from his fertile mind.